

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

PHENOMENOLOGY (HUSSERL) - Layered Solved-Practice Workbook - Philosophy Paper I Western Philosophy 09

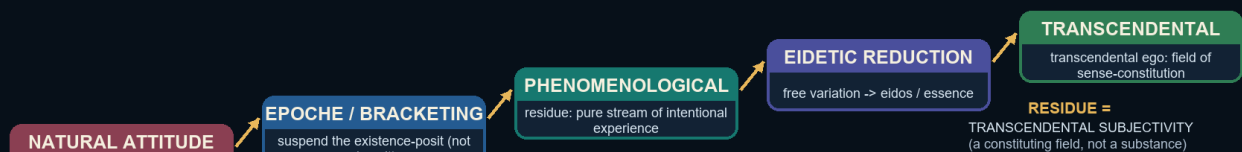
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PHILOSOPHY PAPER I | WESTERN PHILOSOPHY 09

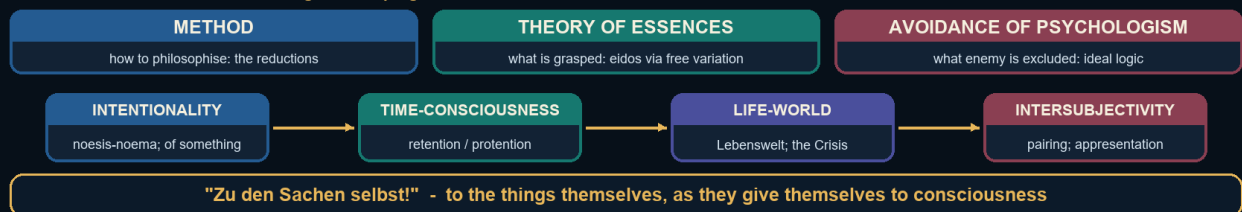
PHENOMENOLOGY - EDMUND HUSSERL

A presuppositionless rigorous science of consciousness: bracket the world, intuit essences, expel psychologism.

THE REDUCTION STAIRCASE - natural attitude to transcendental subjectivity



THREE SYLLABUS TERMS = three stages of the programme



Transcendental idealism, not subjective idealism: constitution is disclosure of sense, never fabrication of the world.

Owens exactly 7 Western Philosophy PYQ parts, 2018-2025 - one each year from 2019 to 2025; none in 2018.

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Workbook Source Audit

- Exact PYQ wording, year and marks: local Western Philosophy Paper I bank, 2018-2025.
- Exactly 7 owner questions, one each in 2019, 2020, 2021, 2022, 2023, 2024 and 2025; 2018 is the only year without one.
- The 2018 Existentialism part on 'Epoche' and Heidegger's rejection of phenomenological reduction is owned by Existentialism and is used here only as a labelled comparison, never counted among the 7.
- Model solutions authored at examiner grade: thesis -> named source / argument -> analysis -> objection/reply -> verdict, each closing with a "Why this earns marks" note.
- MCQs: 32 core plus 8 remedial, exactly 40, strict A-B-C-D rotation ten times.
- Original Mains: one solved 10-marker, one solved 15-marker and one solved 20-marker.
- Contemporary linkage is used sparingly and only as labelled scholarship (Chang Liu, Husserl Studies, 2026); no doctrinal claim rests on it.
- Final consolidated register notes are intentionally excluded from this workbook.

Practice Design

The workbook sequence is the seven exact verified PYQs -> 32 core MCQs -> 8 remedial MCQs -> original 10/15/20-mark Mains practice. There are no register notes and no canonical apparatus block in this workbook.

DIRECTIVE -> THESIS -> DOCTRINE -> NAMED SOURCE / EXAMPLE -> OBJECTION / REPLY -> VERDICT

SOLVED PYQ BANK - EXACTLY 7 VERIFIED OWNER QUESTIONS

Exact wording, year and marks are parsed from the continuous local Western Philosophy Paper I bank for 2018-2025. Phenomenology (Husserl) owns exactly 7 primary parts, one each in 2019, 2020, 2021, 2022, 2023, 2024 and 2025; 2018 is the only year without one. The 2018 Existentialism part that discusses 'Epoche' and Heidegger's rejection of phenomenological reduction is owned by Existentialism and is used here only as a labelled comparison, never counted among the 7.

Solved PYQ 1 - 2019 Q1(b), 10 marks

Question: Can hallucination be regarded as an intentional act by Husserl? Explain.

Model solution

Thesis. Yes - on Husserl's analysis a hallucination is a *paradigmatically* intentional act, because intentionality is defined by *directedness*, not by the existence of a real object.

Doctrine and evidence. For Husserl (transforming Brentano) every act of consciousness is consciousness *of* something; it has two inseparable sides - the **noesis** (the act: perceiving, imagining, hallucinating) and the **noema** (the object precisely *as* meant in that act). Crucially the noema is the "object-as-intended," not a real thing and not an inner picture, so the intended object *need not exist*. A hallucination possesses both moments in full: a genuine act of perceiving (noesis) and a fully determinate percept-as-meant, with shape and colour (noema). It therefore satisfies the definition of an intentional act completely.

Analysis. The point is sharpened by the hyle/morphe structure: in hallucination an intentional **morphe** animates (apprehends) sensuous **hyle** just as in veridical perception, which is why the experience is phenomenally seamless "from the inside." The **principle of principles** (*Ideas I*, section 24) reinforces the verdict: what is given in intuition is to be accepted as it gives itself, within its limits - and the hallucination *is* given as a perceived object. Intentionality concerns the *mode of givenness*, not successful reference.

Qualification. To say the act is intentional is not to say the object is real; the value of the analysis is precisely that it *separates* the two questions - the existential (does it exist?) is bracketed by the epoche, while the intentional (what is meant, and how?) is described. This is also what frees Husserl from the representationalist "veil of ideas": there is no inner image from which we infer an outer thing.

Why this earns marks: it answers the yes/no directly, then *explains* via the exact machinery (noesis-noema, hyle/morphe, principle of principles) rather than asserting; it names the source by section; and it closes on the discriminating point that directedness, not existence, is criterial.

Solved PYQ 2 - 2020 Q1(c), 10 marks

Question: What, according to Husserl, is wrong with psychologism? How does Husserl address the problems with psychologism in his phenomenological method?

Model solution

Thesis. For Husserl psychologism is a category-mistake that confuses the *ideal content* of logic with the *real act* of thinking it; his phenomenological method removes the error by securing a domain of ideal objectivity grasped, but not manufactured, by consciousness.

What is wrong with psychologism. Psychologism (Mill, Lipps, Sigwart - and Husserl's own 1891 *Philosophie der Arithmetik*) holds that logical laws are empirical generalisations about how humans in fact think. In the *Prolegomena to Pure Logic* (1900) Husserl lands four blows: (i) **necessary vs merely probable** - logical laws are necessary, but psychological laws are at best probable inductions, so the former cannot be derived from the latter; (ii) **ideal content vs real act** - "2+2=4" is a timeless meaning, while judging it is a datable psychic event; psychologism conflates them; (iii) **relativism self-refutes** - if truth held only "for beings like us," the claim "truth is relative" would itself be offered as absolutely true (*Anthropologismus*); (iv) **cause vs ground** - that we *must* think non-contradictorily does not explain *why* the law holds; conflating the cause of believing with the ground of validity is the genetic fallacy.

How the method addresses it. The positive result is **ideal objectivity**: logical and mathematical truths are *meanings* (*Bedeutungen*) that subsist independently of any act. Phenomenology then studies consciousness precisely *as the site where such ideal meanings are grasped* - honouring the act/content distinction (real acts, ideal contents) - without reducing the meanings to the acts. This simultaneously defeats psychologism (which denied the ideal) and naive Platonism (which denied that the ideal is accessible to consciousness). Frege's 1894 review had pressed the same act/content confusion.

Qualification. The account presupposes that essential intuition can access ideal objects non-empirically; whether "constitution" later reintroduces a subtler subject-dependence is a separate, harder question (the 2022 issue).

Why this earns marks: it names and orders all four *Prolegomena* arguments, states the positive doctrine (ideal objectivity, act/content), integrates Frege with the correct date, and flags the boundary to the transcendental worry without conflating the two questions.

Solved PYQ 3 - 2021 Q4(a), 20 marks

Question: Present a critical exposition of Husserl's criticism of 'natural attitude'. How does Husserl propose to address the problems involved in natural attitude through his phenomenological method?

Model solution

Thesis. Husserl's criticism of the natural attitude is not that it is false but that it is *uncritical* - it silently posits the world's existence and so blocks the question of how the world comes to have meaning; his remedy is the epoche and the reductions, which lead back to constituting consciousness.

Critical exposition of the criticism. The **natural attitude** (*natürliche Einstellung*) is our default stance; its built-in **general thesis** (*Generalthesis*) is that the world exists, independently of me and always has. This thesis is not a belief we consciously hold but the unquestioned background of everyday life *and* of every natural science - which is why the sciences, resting on it, cannot ground themselves. Husserl's criticism is therefore two-sided and this balance is decisive: the natural attitude is (i) indispensable and true enough for life and science, yet (ii) philosophically naive, because it smuggles an un-examined existence-posit into all inquiry. To read Husserl as saying "common sense is wrong" or "the world does not exist" is to miss the point entirely.

How the method addresses the problem. Because the defect is an uncritical *positing*, the remedy is not denial (that would be the sceptic's counter-positing) but **suspension**. The **epoche** brackets the general thesis - neither affirming nor denying existence - and the **phenomenological reduction** leads us back (*re-ducere*) to the residue: the pure stream of intentional experience, self-given with apodictic evidence. Intentional analysis (noesis-noema) then shows consciousness as essentially world-directed, and the **transcendental reduction** discloses the constituting ego *for which* the world has sense. The world is not lost; it is recovered as *constituted meaning*.

Objection and verdict. Heidegger denies that one can step outside being-in-the-world at all, and Merleau-Ponty holds that a *complete* reduction is impossible - "the most important lesson of the reduction is the impossibility of a complete reduction." These are sympathetic radicalisations, not refutations: they concede the *diagnosis* (the naivety of the natural attitude) while contesting the *cure's* completeness. The critical verdict is that Husserl's criticism inaugurates a new *kind* of philosophising - a science of constitution - rather than a rejection of the world; its lasting worth is the demonstration that objectivity is an achievement to be clarified, not a datum to be assumed.

Why this earns marks: it satisfies both explicit demands (expose the criticism, state the remedy), insists on the examiner-critical two-sided reading, sequences the reductions correctly, and closes with a *judged* verdict citing named critics with an accurate Merleau-Ponty formulation.

Solved PYQ 4 - 2022 Q1(d), 10 marks

Question: What is psychologism? Critically discuss the way Edmund Husserl avoids the problem of psychologism in the discourse of transcendental phenomenology.

Model solution

Thesis. Psychologism is the reduction of logic to empirical psychology; Husserl's transcendental phenomenology avoids it against the *literal* charge, because the transcendental ego is not the empirical psyche and "constitution" is disclosure rather than creation - though whether it escapes a subtler idealism remains contested.

What psychologism is. It is the doctrine that logical laws are empirical generalisations about how human beings in fact think (Mill, Lipps; the early Husserl of 1891). Husserl demolished it in the *Prolegomena* (1900): logic is necessary not merely probable; ideal content is not the real act; species-relative truth self-refutes; and the cause of thinking is not the ground of validity.

The re-entry worry (the heart of this question). After *Ideas* (1913) Husserl locates *all* meaning-constitution in the **transcendental ego**. The objection: if truth is "constituted in transcendental subjectivity," has he not made truth subject-dependent again - psychologism at a higher level?

Husserl's reply, critically discussed. Three moves. (1) The transcendental ego is **not** the empirical psyche: the psyche is a mundane object *within* the world, whereas the transcendental ego is the *condition* under which any world or psyche has sense; reducing to it is therefore not a piece of psychology. (2) **"Constitution" is not creation.** To say the sense of " $2+2=4$ " is constituted in transcendental subjectivity is to say its meaning is *disclosed* there, not that the subject *invents* it; the ideal content stays atemporal and objective, and subjectivity is the *medium of access*, not the *source of validity*. (3) The transcendental ego is **intersubjective** - a community of transcendental egos - so meanings are constituted for *any possible* rational subject, not for one mind.

Verdict. Against the *literal* charge (empirical psychologism) the reply succeeds, because the transcendental ego is by definition non-empirical. Whether it fully escapes a *transcendental* idealism is another matter: Heidegger and Merleau-Ponty judge the "transcendental ego" too close to the idealist subject of the tradition. The honest ruling is graded - Husserl defeats psychologism proper, but relocates rather than dissolves the question of subjective dependence.

Why this earns marks: it distinguishes this question from the 2020 one by foregrounding the *transcendental-turn* charge, reproduces Husserl's three-part reply precisely (non-empirical ego; constitution-as-disclosure; transcendental intersubjectivity), and delivers a graded verdict rather than a flat acquittal.

Solved PYQ 5 - 2023 Q3(b), 15 marks

Question: Elucidate the significance of bracketing and reduction in Husserl's phenomenological method.

Model solution

Thesis. Bracketing and reduction are the moves that *create phenomenology's subject-matter*: by suspending the existence-posit they open a field of pure givenness, and by leading consciousness back to itself they make possible a science of essences and the disclosure of the transcendental ego. Their significance is thus methodological, epistemic and ontological at once.

Exposition. The **epoche** (bracketing, *Einklammerung*) suspends the general thesis of the natural attitude - the standing assumption that the world exists independently. It neither affirms nor denies existence; it *withholds assent*, so that what is described is freed from prejudice. The **phenomenological reduction** is the positive counterpart: it leads us back (*re-ducere*) from the posited world to the **residue** - the whole stream of intentional experience exactly as lived, given with apodictic self-evidence. Nothing describable is lost; only the existence-frame is changed.

Significance - why they matter. Three interlocking purposes. (i) They **secure a domain of indubitable givenness** on which a rigorous science can be built. (ii) They **avoid the Cartesian slide into substance**: what the reduction reveals is not a *res cogitans* but a relational field (intentionality), so there is no mind-body gap to bridge and no need for a divine guarantee of the external world. (iii) They **make a science of essences possible** - only by suspending the factual does the *essential* become visible, so bracketing is the gateway to the eidetic reduction and to transcendental subjectivity. Of these, only the third is uniquely Husserl's; the first two he reaches without Descartes' costs.

Objection and verdict. Merleau-Ponty's caution - that a *complete* reduction is impossible, since we are always already engaged in the world - limits the ideal without destroying its use: the reduction is an asymptotic discipline, not a single completed act. The verdict: without bracketing and reduction, phenomenology collapses back into naive realism or empirical psychology; *with* them, it earns its claim to be a presuppositionless science of how meaning is constituted.

Why this earns marks: it reads "significance" as *why-they-are-needed* rather than mere definition, gives the three graded purposes with their consequences, distinguishes phenomenological from eidetic reduction, and closes with a named limitation and a defended verdict.

Solved PYQ 6 - 2024 Q4(b), 15 marks

Question: Why does Husserl think that essences exhibit a kind of continuity between consciousness and being? Discuss.

Model solution

Thesis. Husserl holds that essences reveal a continuity between consciousness and being because every essence is disclosed only as the *correlate* of a corresponding mode of consciousness; being and consciousness are therefore two sides of one intentional structure - a **correlational a priori** - not two separate realms needing a bridge.

The theory of essences. By the **eidetic reduction** Husserl moves from an individual fact to its essence: taking any example and subjecting it to **free imaginative variation** (*freie Variation*), one watches what *cannot* be removed without the example ceasing to be an instance of its kind. That invariant is the **eidōs** or **Wesen**, grasped directly in **Wesensschau** (essential intuition), which is a *categorical* intuition (from *Logical Investigations* VI), not abstraction and not mysticism. Essences are ordered - **formal** essences belong to any object whatever (formal ontology), **material/regional** essences to a domain (physical thing, living body, mind, number), each with its own **regional ontology**.

Establishing the continuity. The decisive step is that essences are never encountered "bare." A physical-thing essence is given only in and through *perceiving*; a numerical essence only in and through *counting*; a melody-essence only in and through *time-constituting* consciousness. Object-essence and act-type are strictly correlated: to describe the essence of a kind of object *is* to describe the essence of the consciousness in which such an object can be given. Hence Husserl's claim that consciousness is not sealed off from being but is *of* being throughout - the eidetic method itself is the evidence for the correlational thesis. Method and metaphysics are one movement.

Guard and verdict. This continuity must not be misread as **subjective idealism**: Husserl does not say objects are bundles of *my* ideas, but that the *sense* "being" is constituted in and for consciousness (a transcendental, not a Berkeleyan, claim). The critical question is whether the correlational a priori genuinely *bridges* consciousness and being or merely *redefines* being as correlate; the defensible verdict is that Husserl earns a continuity of *sense* - being is always being-as-given - while the stronger metaphysical continuity remains a programmatic promise developed only in the genetic and *Crisis* phases.

Why this earns marks: it answers *why* (not just *what*) by grounding the continuity in the correlational a priori, links the eidetic method to the metaphysical claim, names the material/formal and regional-ontology apparatus, and explicitly guards against the subjective-idealism misreading before judging how far the continuity is earned.

Solved PYQ 7 - 2025 Q4(a), 20 marks

Question: How is Husserl's account of "I think" different from that of Descartes? Critically discuss.

Model solution

Thesis. Husserl and Descartes begin from the same indubitable "I think," but Husserl *de-substantialises* it: where Descartes infers a thinking *thing* (*res cogitans*) that then needs God to recover the world, Husserl's "I think" names a *constituting function* that never lost the world and is essentially world-directed.

The shared starting point. Both seek a presuppositionless beginning in the apodictic self-givenness of the thinking act; Husserl explicitly casts his reductions as a radicalised Cartesian meditation. The agreement is real and should be stated first.

Three divergences. (i) **Substance vs function.** Descartes slides from "I think" to "I am a thing that thinks," positing a mental substance. Husserl refuses the inference: the **transcendental ego** is not a *thing* left inside the brackets but the *field of sense-constitution*, that *for which* anything has meaning. (ii) **The world: lost vs bracketed.** Descartes' doubt *loses* the external world and must reclaim it through God's benevolence. Husserl needs no such bridge, because the world was never lost - only *bracketed*; meaning-constitution already contains the world as its intentional correlate. (iii) **Worldless vs world-constituting.** Descartes' ego could in principle exist alone; Husserl's ego is *essentially* constituting a world - without the world-as-meant there would be nothing for consciousness to be consciousness *of*.

Two further guards. Husserl's ego is also *not* Kant's merely formal "I think": it has **content** - habitualities and sedimentations, a *history* of constituting (grounded in retention). And the specter of **transcendental solipsism** - if the world is constituted by my ego, how are there others? - is met in the Fifth *Cartesian Meditation* by pairing and **analogical appresentation**: the other is constituted as an alter ego whose very *inaccessibility* is the sense "other."

Critical verdict. Husserl's account is best read as the cogito *radicalised*: by converting Descartes' worldless substance into a world-constituting life he dissolves the mind-body and external-world problems that Descartes bequeathed. Yet critics (Heidegger, Merleau-Ponty) charge that the "transcendental ego" remains too close to the idealist subject, and Levinas that the alter-ego construal erases the Other. The judged conclusion: Husserl improves decisively on Descartes' *thing*-ontology of mind, while inheriting a residual idealism that his successors set out to overcome.

Why this earns marks: it opens with the shared ground, develops exactly the three canonical divergences, adds the Kant guard and the solipsism/Fifth-Meditation resolution, and ends with a defended verdict rather than a bare list of contrasts.

ORIGINAL MCQ MASTERY SET - EXACTLY 40 QUESTIONS

Questions 1-32 are core coverage across all ten subtopics; Questions 33-40 are remedial items targeting the most common misreadings. Correct answers rotate strictly A -> B -> C -> D 10 times.

MCQ 1

Husserl's phenomenology is best described as an attempt to establish:

- A. a presuppositionless, rigorous science of consciousness B. an empirical psychology of mental states C. a metaphysical proof of the existence of God D. a historical survey of philosophical worldviews

Correct answer: A

Explanation: The programme is a presuppositionless rigorous science (strenge Wissenschaft, the 1911 Logos manifesto); it opposes naturalism/psychologism and historicism alike.

MCQ 2

The motto 'Zu den Sachen selbst!' ('to the things themselves') primarily demands:

- A. a return to naive realism about physical objects B. fidelity to how the matters themselves are given in experience C. the reduction of philosophy to natural science D. the abandonment of description in favour of speculation

Correct answer: B

Explanation: 'Sachen' means matters/subject-matters, not physical things; the slogan calls for fidelity to givenness, the opposite of naive realism.

MCQ 3

The three components of the syllabus clause (method, theory of essences, avoidance of psychologism) are best understood as:

- A. three unrelated doctrines B. three successive historical periods of Husserl's life C. three stages of one project: how to look, what is seen, and what is barred D. three separate replies to Heidegger

Correct answer: C

Explanation: They form one movement: the method yields the field, the theory of essences describes its structures, and the exclusion of psychologism guarantees objectivity.

MCQ 4

The 'general thesis' (Generalthesis) of the natural attitude is:

- A. the belief that God guarantees knowledge B. the claim that the laws of logic are empirical C. the doctrine that essences are Platonic Forms D. the standing, unquestioned positing of the world as existing independently of me

Correct answer: D

Explanation: The Generalthesis is the background existence-posit that operates before any inquiry, not a consciously held belief.

MCQ 5

Husserl's criticism of the natural attitude is best captured by which statement?

- A. it is not false but uncritical, and so blocks the question of how the world comes to have meaning B. it is simply false and must be rejected outright C. it proves that the world does not exist D. it is identical to Cartesian doubt

Correct answer: A

Explanation: The verdict is two-sided: the natural attitude is indispensable for life and science yet philosophically naive; it is suspended, never refuted.

MCQ 6

On Husserl's view, the natural sciences:

A. operate from outside the natural attitude B. remain within the natural attitude and therefore cannot ground themselves C. have already carried out the epoche D. take the transcendental ego as their object

Correct answer: B

Explanation: The sciences presuppose an independently existing domain; only a stance outside the general thesis can ask how any domain is constituted as meaningful.

MCQ 7

The epoche (bracketing) is best defined as:

A. the denial of the external world's existence B. a proof that only the mind exists C. the suspension of the existence-posit, neither affirming nor denying it D. an empirical hypothesis about the causes of perception

Correct answer: C

Explanation: The epoche withholds assent to the general thesis; it decides nothing about existence and is not scepticism.

MCQ 8

The decisive difference between Husserl's epoche and Cartesian doubt is that:

A. both deny existence in order to reach certainty B. the epoche seeks a substance while doubt seeks a field C. doubt is passive whereas the epoche is an inference D. doubt denies the doubtful to find the indubitable, while the epoche merely suspends the existence-posit

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Descartes denies; Husserl neither affirms nor denies. The epoche is a methodological neutralisation, not a hunt for an indubitable substance.

MCQ 9

The 'residue' left by the phenomenological reduction is:

A. the pure stream of intentional experience, given with apodictic self-evidence B. a Cartesian thinking substance (res cogitans) C. the empirical psyche studied by psychology D. nothing whatever

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Bracketing the existence-claim retains the full experiential content as the field in which all meaning is constituted.

MCQ 10

Which pair names two genuinely distinct operations?

A. epoche and bracketing B. the phenomenological reduction (brackets existence) and the eidetic reduction (extracts essence) C. noesis and the act-side of the experience D. the residue and pure experience

Correct answer: B

Explanation: A common trap: only B lists two different moves; the other options are pairs of synonyms.

MCQ 11

Intentionality, for Husserl, means that:

A. all mental states are unconscious B. consciousness must always have a real external object C. consciousness is always consciousness of something (essential directedness) D. the mind intends to act morally

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Directedness is essential; the object is the object-as-meant and need not exist. The thesis is taken from Brentano but transformed.

MCQ 12

In the noesis-noema correlation, the noema is:

A. the raw sensory matter of the experience B. the physical object that causes the perception C. an inner mental picture inspected by the mind D. the object precisely as it is intended in the act

Correct answer: D

Explanation: The noema is the 'object-as-meant', not an inner image; treating it as an image would revive the representationalist veil of ideas.

MCQ 13

Can a hallucination be regarded as an intentional act?

A. Yes, because it has a genuine noesis and a full noema, so it is paradigmatically intentional B. No, because intentional acts require an actually existing object C. No, because hallucinations lack any noema D. Only if the experience is later confirmed as veridical

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Intentionality requires directedness, not existence; a hallucination has both a real act and a determinate object-as-meant.

MCQ 14

The 'principle of principles' (Ideas I, section 24) holds that:

A. logic is grounded in empirical psychology B. whatever is given in intuition is to be accepted as it gives itself, within the limits in which it is given C. the world exists independently of consciousness D. essences are separately existing Forms

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Originary intuitive givenness is the ultimate source of legitimacy for knowledge.

MCQ 15

In the hyle/morphe distinction, the hyle is:

A. the intentional form that animates the matter B. the object precisely as meant C. non-intentional sensory matter, lived through rather than looked at D. a Platonic essence grasped in intuition

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Hyle is raw sense-data; the morphe (form) animates or apprehends it (Auffassung) so that the whole act intends an object.

MCQ 16

The anti-sense-datum implication of the hyle/morphe doctrine is that:

- A. we perceive sense-data and infer the world behind them
- B. the hyle is itself the object we perceive
- C. consciousness contains inner pictures matched against outer things
- D. the raw sensory element is never itself an object, so there is no 'veil of ideas' to cross

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Hyle is lived through, not looked at: we perceive the tomato, not a red patch from which we deduce it. Merleau-Ponty and Sartre object that any formless hyle re-imports empiricist sensation.

MCQ 17

The three moments of the living present are:

- A. retention, primal impression and protention
- B. thesis, antithesis and synthesis
- C. epoche, reduction and constitution
- D. hyle, morphe and noema

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Retention holds the just-past, the primal impression (Urimpression) is the now-phase, and protention anticipates the just-to-come.

MCQ 18

The single most examinable distinction in the time-lectures is that:

- A. protention is identical to recollection
- B. retention (primary memory) is part of the present perception, whereas recollection (secondary memory) re-presents what is no longer present
- C. the primal impression is a datable brain-event
- D. retention is an inference from present data

Correct answer: B

Explanation: I still hear the just-played note (retention); I do not remember it. Recollection is a fresh re-presentation (Vergegenwartigung) of the absent.

MCQ 19

The editorial history of 'On the Phenomenology of the Consciousness of Internal Time' (lectures 1893-1917) is that the text was:

- A. published by Husserl himself in 1900
- B. written entirely by Heidegger
- C. edited by Edith Stein and published by Heidegger in 1928
- D. first published in French in 1931

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Edith Stein prepared the manuscript and Heidegger published it in 1928; always flag this editorial history when citing the work.

MCQ 20

Free imaginative variation is the method by which Husserl:

- A. counts empirical instances to form an average
- B. deduces essences from self-evident axioms
- C. proves that the external world exists
- D. varies an example freely in fantasy to find the invariant that cannot be removed, i.e. the eidos

Correct answer: D

Explanation: The eidos is seen (Wesensschau) as the limit the variations cannot cross; it is not an average abstracted from cases.

MCQ 21

Wesensschau (essential intuition) is:

A. a categorial intuition in which the universal is given, neither mere abstraction nor mysticism B. a mystical vision of Platonic Forms C. an empirical generalisation from instances D. an inference from analogy

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Already in Logical Investigations VI Husserl argues that categorial forms are intuited; the essence is given, not inferred.

MCQ 22

Which distinction does Husserl draw within the domain of essences?

A. between real acts and ideal contents B. between formal essences (holding for any object whatever) and material or regional essences (domain-specific) C. between retention and protention D. between noesis and noema

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Formal ontology covers any object as such; each material region (physical thing, living body, mind, number) has its own regional ontology with its own a priori laws.

MCQ 23

Husserl's claim of a 'continuity between consciousness and being' rests on:

A. a proof that objects are bundles of ideas B. God's guarantee of the external world C. the correlational a priori: being is given only as the correlate of a mode of consciousness D. the identity of hyle and morphe

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Object-essence and act-type are strictly correlated, so consciousness is of being throughout. This must not be misread as subjective idealism.

MCQ 24

The transcendental ego is:

A. the empirical psyche studied by psychology B. Descartes' res cogitans (a thinking substance) C. Kant's merely formal, logical 'I think' D. the constituting field of sense, bearing habitualities and sedimentation

Correct answer: D

Explanation: It is none of the three rejected options; unlike Kant's bare 'I think' it has content, a history of constituting grounded in retention.

MCQ 25

A key difference between Husserl's 'I think' and Descartes' cogito is that:

A. Husserl refuses the inference to a thinking substance and needs no God-bridge, since the world was bracketed, not lost B. Husserl, like Descartes, infers a res cogitans from the thinking act C. Husserl's ego is worldless and could exist entirely alone D. Descartes' ego is essentially world-constituting

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Husserl de-substantialises the cogito: the transcendental ego is a constituting function, and the world returns as its intentional correlate.

MCQ 26

The Lebenswelt (life-world) is:

- A. the mathematised world of modern physics B. the pre-scientific, pre-theoretical world of lived experience, the ultimate ground of evidence C. a Platonic realm of subsisting essences D. another name for the transcendental ego

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Science abstracts from and idealises the life-world (Galilean mathematisation) and forgets its own origin in it, which Husserl calls the 'crisis'.

MCQ 27

Which is the correct statement about the publication of the Crisis?

- A. Husserl published the complete book in his lifetime in 1936 B. it appeared first in a French translation in 1931 C. Parts I-II appeared in 1936; the full text was published posthumously only in 1954 (Husserliana VI, ed. Biemel; Eng. tr. Carr 1970) D. it was written by Heidegger in 1927

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Husserl died in 1938 leaving the work unfinished; it must not be cited as a finished 1936 book.

MCQ 28

Psychologism is the doctrine that:

- A. logical truths form a realm of ideal objects B. essences are Platonic Forms C. the world must be bracketed to be known D. the laws of logic are empirical generalisations about how human beings in fact think

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Represented by Mill, Lipps and Sigwart, and by the early Husserl of the Philosophie der Arithmetik (1891).

MCQ 29

Which is one of Husserl's four Prolegomena arguments against psychologism?

- A. logical laws are necessary, but psychological laws are at best probable inductions B. logic is simply a branch of physics C. truth is whatever we feel compelled to believe D. essences are images in the mind

Correct answer: A

Explanation: The other three: ideal content vs real act; species-relativism self-refutes; and the cause of our thinking is not the ground of validity (the genetic fallacy).

MCQ 30

The positive doctrine Husserl sets against psychologism is:

- A. that logic ultimately reduces to psychology after all B. ideal objectivity: real acts grasp ideal, atemporal meanings C. Platonism in the naive sense D. that truth is species-relative

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Real acts, ideal contents: this dual recognition defeats both psychologism (which denied the ideal) and naive Platonism (which denied the ideal is accessible).

MCQ 31

In the Fifth Cartesian Meditation the other subject is reached through:

A. an argument from analogy, i.e. an inductive inference to a hidden mind B. the direct, originary givenness of the other's own stream of experience C. pairing (Paarung) and analogical appresentation, a passive transfer of sense rather than an inference D. a proof grounded in the veracity of God

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Appresentation co-intends the other's inner life (like the unseen back of a table seen through its front); Husserl expressly denies that it is an inference.

MCQ 32

Husserl's actual task in the Fifth Meditation is:

A. to prove that other minds exist B. to refute solipsism by citing empirical evidence C. to deduce the other ego from the idea of God D. to clarify how the sense 'another subject, for whom the world is also there' is constituted, with its proper evidence

Correct answer: D

Explanation: The epoche has suspended existence-questions, so reading the Meditation as a failed proof of other minds mistakes the task.

Remedial MCQ 33

Remedial - suspension vs denial. Which statement about the epoche is correct?

A. it suspends the existence-posit and does not deny the world B. it proves that only the mind exists C. it is identical to Cartesian doubt D. it is an empirical hypothesis about the causes of perception

Correct answer: A

Explanation: The epoche brackets a positing; it is suspension, not denial, and therefore not scepticism.

Remedial MCQ 34

Remedial - retention vs recollection. Retention differs from recollection in that:

A. retention re-presents something that is no longer present B. retention is part of the present perception, whereas recollection re-presents the absent C. the two are exactly the same act under different names D. recollection is the passive, continuous holding of the just-past

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Retention is primary memory within the living now; recollection is secondary memory, a re-presentation (Vergegenwartigung) of what is no longer present.

Remedial MCQ 35

Remedial - intentional objects. An intentional object, on Husserl's account:

A. must always be a real, existing thing B. is an inner mental picture inspected by the mind C. need not exist: centaurs, ghosts and hallucinations are full intentional objects D. is identical to the hyletic data

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Directedness, not successful reference, is criterial; the object is the object-as-meant.

Remedial MCQ 36

Remedial - essences are not Forms. Husserl's eidos (essence) is best described as:

A. a Form residing in a separate Platonic heaven B. an average abstracted from many instances C. a psychological idea occurring in a particular mind D. the necessary structure of the object as such, given in intuition

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Neither Platonic separation (chorismos) nor psychologism: the essence is the invariant grasped in Wesensschau.

Remedial MCQ 37

Remedial - ego is not a substance. The transcendental ego is NOT:

A. a Cartesian res cogitans, that is, a mental substance B. a constituting field of sense C. the condition under which any world has meaning D. a bearer of habitualities and sedimented history

Correct answer: A

Explanation: It is a function, not a thing; options B, C and D are correct descriptions of it.

Remedial MCQ 38

Remedial - Crisis provenance. Which is the safe scholarly way to cite the Crisis?

A. 'the Crisis (1936)', a book Husserl completed and published in his lifetime B. 'the Crisis (Parts I-II 1936; full text posthumously 1954)' C. 'the Crisis (1954)', Husserl's own final publication D. 'the Crisis', first published in French in 1931

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Husserl died in 1938 leaving the work unfinished; the full text is Husserliana VI (1954), edited by Walter Biemel, English translation David Carr (1970).

Remedial MCQ 39

Remedial - the Fifth Meditation's aim. The Fifth Cartesian Meditation is most accurately read as:

A. a successful proof that other minds exist B. a refutation of the existence of the external world C. an analysis of how the sense 'other subject' is constituted, in which the other's inaccessibility is itself constitutive of that sense D. an empirical psychology of empathy

Correct answer: C

Explanation: It dissolves the traditional problem of other minds rather than solving it as ordinarily posed; non-originality is a necessity, not a defect.

Remedial MCQ 40

Remedial - provenance discipline. Which scholarly caution is correct?

A. Frege's 1894 review is the proven cause of Husserl's anti-psychologistic turn B. the astronomy-of-astronomers sentence is a verbatim quotation from Frege C. the appresentation of the other is an argument from analogy D. the astronomy line is a textbook paraphrase (not a Frege quotation) and Frege's causal influence is disputed (Mohanty, 1982)

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Provenance discipline: paraphrase not quotation; Follesdal (1958) argued for Frege's decisive influence, Mohanty (1982) argued from the manuscripts that Husserl's anti-psychologism was already developing.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

Three original questions authored for this package (not PYQs), one each at 10, 15 and 20 marks, with full model solutions.

Original Mains 1

Original 10-mark | Philosophy Paper I, Western Philosophy - Phenomenology (Husserl) | Answer in about 150 words

Question: Explain Husserl's distinction between hyle and morphe. How does it undermine the sense-datum theory of perception?

Model solution

Thesis. The hyle/morphe distinction separates the non-intentional sensory *matter* of an experience from the intentional *form* that animates it, and in doing so removes the very object - the free-floating sense-datum - on which the sense-datum theory depends.

Exposition. The **hyle** is raw sensory matter (colour-, tone-, touch-data) that by itself points at nothing; the **morphe** is the intentional form that *apprehends* or animates it (*Auffassung*), so that only the whole act intends an object. The same red hyle, differently animated, is a ball, a signal, or a smear of paint.

Critical point. For the sense-datum theory (Locke's ideas, Russell's sense-data) we perceive an inner sensory *object* and infer the external thing behind it - the "veil of ideas." Husserl blocks this: hyle is *lived through*, *not looked at*; it is a dependent moment found only in reflection, never itself the object perceived. We perceive the tomato, not a red patch. Hence there is no inner object and no sceptical gap - though Merleau-Ponty and Sartre reply that retaining any formless hyle re-imports the empiricist sensation Husserl meant to defeat.

Why this earns marks: it defines both terms, states the mechanism (animation/apprehension), draws the precise anti-representationalist consequence, and registers the standard objection - all within the word budget.

Original Mains 2

Original 15-mark | Philosophy Paper I, Western Philosophy - Phenomenology (Husserl) | Answer in about 250 words

Question: Analyse Husserl's account of inner time-consciousness. Why is retention not a species of recollection, and what does the distinction accomplish?

Model solution

Thesis. Husserl explains how temporal objects (a melody, a sentence) can be experienced as wholes by giving the present an internal structure - retention, primal impression, protention - and the crux is that retention *belongs to the present perception*, whereas recollection re-presents the absent.

Exposition. If consciousness held only an instantaneous now-point, we could never hear a melody, only isolated tones. Husserl's living present has three moments: the **primal impression** (*Urimpression*, the now-phase, source-point of constitution); **retention**, the just-elapsed phase *still held* in the present and sinking in clarity (the "comet's tail"); and **protention**, the empty anticipation of the just-to-come, which can be *disappointed* when the melody turns unexpectedly.

The decisive distinction. **Retention (primary memory)** is a *passive, continuous* part of the current perception - I still *hear* the note just played as just-past. **Recollection (secondary memory, Wiedererinnerung)** is an *active re-presentation (Vergegenwartigung)* of something no longer present - a fresh act that makes the past present again. Collapsing the two would make hearing a melody a rapid series of memories, destroying the phenomenon.

What it accomplishes. The account (i) answers **Hume** - the self is found in the constituting flow, not among the discrete contents; (ii) grounds **identity and habituality** through sedimentation of the retained past; and (iii) is transformed by **Heidegger** into ecstatic temporality. Husserl candidly reaches an "absolute flow" that "constitutes its own unity," conceding a limit.

Provenance. Lectures of 1893-1917, edited by Edith Stein, published by Heidegger in 1928 - flag this editorial history.

Why this earns marks: it reconstructs the three-fold structure, nails the most-examinable retention/recollection contrast with the correct German terms, states three distinct pay-offs, and closes with accurate provenance.

Original Mains 3

Original 20-mark | Philosophy Paper I, Western Philosophy - Phenomenology (Husserl) | Answer in about 250 words

Question: Does Husserl's transcendental phenomenology escape the charge of solipsism? Critically evaluate with reference to the Fifth Cartesian Meditation.

Model solution

Thesis. Husserl escapes solipsism as a *doctrine* - he shows how the sense "another subject" is constituted, with the other's inaccessibility built into that very sense - but the method that reaches this result, beginning from a sphere purified of others, arguably does not escape solipsism as a *procedure*.

The problem. After the transcendental reduction, everything, including other people, has the status of *sense constituted for my ego*; the threat is **transcendental solipsism**, which Husserl treats as the gravest objection to his own programme.

First correct the question. Husserl is *not* proving that other minds exist (the epoche suspended existence-positing). He asks how the sense "another subject, for whom the world is also there" is constituted with its proper evidence - and saying this is the strongest single move on the topic.

The constitution. (i) A reduction to the **sphere of ownness** (*Eigenheitssphäre*); (ii) my **lived body** (*Leib*) as the unique absolute "here"; (iii) another body resembling mine in *behaviour*; (iv) **pairing** (*Paarung*), a passive association; (v) **appresentation** - the other's subjectivity is co-intended, not presented, an *analogising transfer of sense*, not an inference; (vi) the **alter ego**, "as if I were over there." Non-originality is a necessity: if I lived the other's stream originally, he would be *me*.

Evaluation. **Schutz** presses circularity - the ownness sphere already presupposes the sense "other"; **Sartre** counters with the Look; **Levinas** charges that the alter-ego construal erases otherness; **Heidegger** holds that Dasein is always already *Mitsein*, so the problem is spurious. The reply to Levinas concedes rather than answers.

Verdict. The permanent achievement is disposing of the traditional other-minds problem; the residual failure is structural - an analysis that must *begin* alone reaches the other only as a modification of the self. Solipsism-as-doctrine is defeated; solipsism-as-method is not.

Why this earns marks: it reframes the question correctly, reconstructs the six-step constitution with exact terminology, marshals four named critics with their replies, and delivers a graded, defended verdict.